

What it means if you...

What each shortlisted link would mean for six ways of working

Prepared 9 November 2026 · every figure is computed from the rotas

One person, a year, cover weeks aside. Earlies and lates are counted Monday to Saturday, as Sunday is overtime. Pounds are gross, at the CEA rate of £21.49; the Pay Calculator in the app estimates a payslip. **Bold** marks the clear best of the three for that person.

IF YOU...	TODAY	BALANCED V6	LEVEL CROSSING	MIDDLE GROUND
...prefer earlies				
Fewer, longer earlies on every link, in longer runs; Balanced V6's runs are the shortest of the three.				
Earlies a year	88	84	84	84
Starting at 06:20, the open, a year	62	50	**58**	48
Average early	7h 59m	**8h 06m**	8h 07m	8h 09m
Earlies over 8h 30m, a year	0	2	**0**	**0**
Earlies finishing at 13:35 or 13:45, a year	26	**20**	**20**	12
Weeks of earlies, or of lates, in a row	2, up to 3	3, up to 5	5, up to 7	5, up to 7
...prefer lates				
More lates on every link, in longer runs, and every closer shorter, the weekday's by half an hour.				
Lates a year	88	94	94	94
Average late, closers included	8h 29m	8h 24m	8h 23m	**8h 21m**
Longest closing shift, weekday	8h 40m	8h 10m	8h 10m	8h 10m
Finishing at 23:00 or later, any day, a year	39	42	42	42
...swap earlies for lates, for the overtime				
Swapping the shortest earlies brings less overtime than today on every link. Balanced V6 keeps the most from its 13:35 and 13:45 finishes, Middle Ground the least. Other swaps may still add paid time.				
A late against an early, same day, on average	32 min longer	17 min longer	16 min longer	12 min longer
Each 13:35 or 13:45 early swapped for the day's longest late	+34h 40m	+23h 20m	+21h 40m	+13h 00m
That overtime, gross, at time and a quarter	about £930	about £630	about £580	about £350
...work your share of Sundays and no other overtime				
About £200 to £350 a year less on every link, gross: two more Saturdays at time and a quarter, but fewer, shorter Sundays.				
Sundays a year, at time and a half	21	20	20	20
Sunday hours a year	177	167	167	164
Premium and overtime pay, against today	—	about £200 less	about £200 less	about £350 less
...work no overtime at all				
A little better off on every link — about £90 to £140 a year, gross, from two more Saturdays at time and a quarter.				
Saturday hours a year, at time and a quarter	213	238	237	231
Premium pay, against today	—	about £140 more	about £130 more	about £90 more
...save your leave for long breaks				
All three keep today's leave: four full weeks off, Sunday to Saturday, take 14 days, and 14 days buy 30 days off at best. Each has fewer three- and four-day breaks than today; Balanced V6 has the most of the three, for 22 single rest days a year where today has 10.				
Leave for four full weeks off, Sunday to Saturday	14 days	14 days	14 days	14 days
Days off in a row from 14 days' leave, at best	30	30	30	30
Rest-day breaks of three or four days, a year	about 13	**about 6**	about 2	about 4
Whoever you are				
What every shortlisted link gives everyone, against today, on the set duties. If a cover week falls badly, Balanced V6 can make ten days in a row, one more than today.				
Full weekends off a year	10	12	**14**	**14**
Most days in a row	7, up to 9	5, up to 10	5, up to 6	5, up to 7
Shortest rest between shifts	12h 30m	14h 20m	14h 20m	**14h 35m**
Avoidable fatigue warnings	4, up to 5	0, up to 4	0	0, up to 1

How these are worked out. Over 52 weeks, two turns of a 26-week link, so a design's figures are everyone's; today's, on 20 weeks, are averages. An early starts before 11:00, a late at 11:00 or after. A swap is counted on the same day: each early against that day's average late, and each 13:35 or 13:45 early — the only earlies that finish before 14:00 — swapped for that day's longest late. That is the most these particular short-early swaps could make, not a forecast: it assumes a partner for every swap, and the extra time paid at time and a quarter ("Overtime 1.25" on a payslip).

The swap rows are not ranked: which link suits a swapper depends on which swaps they make. Nor are the no-overtime rows: the three are within one Saturday duty's hours a year. The average late includes the closers. The Sunday figure is to £50; the others are to £10. Leave: a working day Monday to Saturday costs a day's leave, a rest day or a Sunday none. "Up to" is the worst place a cover week's duties could fall. Fatigue warnings are reported against the ORR's good-practice list, never as pass or fail.